



FLAT CHAT NEWSLETTER
AUSTIN-HEALEY OWNERS CLUB (NSW) INC
ABN: 87 630 303 136

VOL. 7 ISSUE
Dec 2020

#12

COMING EVENTS

Due to Covid-19 and directions from the Australian and New South Wales governments all AHOC face to face meetings, runs and events are generally cancelled until further notice.

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**Please note the AHOC's new
PO Box address below.**



POST: AHOC (NSW) Inc
PO Box 6494
North Ryde NSW 2113

EMAIL: enquiries@austinhealeynsw.com.au
WEB: www.austinhealeynsw.com.au
FB: www.facebook.com/groups/681723625314952/

Normally our monthly meetings are held at North Ryde Golf Club, on the 1st Thursday of each month commencing at 7.30pm. This may change to Strathfield Golf Club from February 2021.

Members and guests are welcome to join us for dinner in the restaurant from 5.30pm.



November Workshop

Thanks to Julie Lee and input from Colin Rule

To celebrate a beautiful first Saturday in November, there was a very healthy gathering at Colin Rule's regular monthly workshop on the Central Coast. Some 18 attendees turned out on the day with their various cars.

Members attending on the day included Garry and myself, hosts Colin and Kerrie Rule, John Wakeling and Kaye McIntyre, Scott Parry-Jones, Ian Richter, Bruce Ewan, Jim Phillips, Roger Ramsay, Mark McAllan, Ken Offord, Geoff Smith, Gordon Lynas and non-members Louise and Paul Hicken. As the person organising the upcoming Sydney workshops,

Bruce Ewan was busy checking out the goings on to see what it was all about.

Ken Offord had been experiencing a few gremlins with his BJ7, so it received some head gasket testing by resident mechanic Steve Bromfield and the other experts on hand. The driver's seat of Jim Phillips' BN4 was again lowered and Colin's beautiful under restoration BN2 was wheeled out of the end garage at some stage. I was busy checking out Kerrie's new compost bins (repurposed pieces of air conditioning duct – very clever) so missed what was going on in the workshop!



PRESIDENT'S MESSAGE

HAPPY CHRISTMAS to everyone!

And as it is Christmas it is time to PARTY! Yes! Our next major function, OUR VERY FIRST FULL CLUB FACE TO FACE MEETING SINCE COVID STRUCK WILL BE OUR CHRISTMAS PARTY on 17 DECEMBER. We will have a short pause now for you to recover your breath after cheering loudly the restart of proper meetings. So, after a hiatus of many months we will be able to share the same room with club friends and tuck into a tasty meal and a glass or two of liquid merriment. Check out this edition of Flat Chat for details of how you can book your seat(s) if you haven't already done so.

We had been hoping the North Ryde Golf Club would find a way to host us for our monthly meetings as well as Christmas, however, so far that hasn't been able to happen. So, we have been looking at alternative venues and you can check out one possibility for monthly meetings at the Strathfield Golf Club by coming along



to our Christmas Party. (See! Another reason to be at the Christmas Party! No excuses.) No doubt the festivities will be a bit more constrained this year as there are sure to be some Covid restrictions still in place on 17 December. Whatever those might be, please take notice of any requests that Strathfield Golf Club personnel might make of us. We wouldn't want our first visit to this venue to be our last.

That is the big AHOC news of the moment. Restrictions continue to limit meetings to small groups as pioneered by Colin Rule with his very popular first Saturday 'workshops' on the Central Coast. Next year we will be extending the



Gordon Lynas – 0403 198 343 – gordonlynas@optusnet.com.au

concept by holding some monthly workshops at a number of venues in Sydney.

Bruce Ewan, our Membership Secretary will no doubt be letting members know the dates, locations, and booking procedures soon. As we have to expect Covid to still be around next year it is very likely that the number able to attend will be quite limited. To avoid the risk of our hosts, or the

Cont' on page 6

COMMITTEE LIST - 2020

Club Patron—Ross Bond

President - Gordon Lynas
4 Wanari Road
Terrey Hills NSW 2084
(02) 9944 4789
0403 198 343
gordonlynas@optusnet.com.au

Vice-President - Geoff Smith
0458 777 339
m.gpsmith@bigpond.com

Secretary - Julie Lee
0421 598 755
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Historian - Joe Armour
0419 233 099
joea6@bigpond.com

Membership Secretary - Christine Lyttle
0410 201 373
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Regalia - Colin Rule
0467 563 523
coolibahconvertible@bigpond.com

Technical Officer - Neville Stirton
0414 472 877
stirton@bigpond.net.au

Club Registrar - Patrick Quinn
(Inc Conditional Registration)
Please send all Conditional Registration documents to Patrick's address or email at left

Public Relations - Ross Penman
0408 465 547
penmans@bigpond.com

Webmaster - Jim Phillips
0413 589 306
jjjimbeau@gmail.com

Public Officer - Alan Mitchell
PO Box 123
Marulan 2579
0412 898 656
mitchellaj@ozemail.com.au

Non-Committee Positions
CSCA Delegate - Colin Goldsmith

Librarian - Ron Strange

CMC Delegates - Ray Roberts
Ian Clayton

Welfare Officer - Pamela Ross 0408 201 226

Display Day Coordinators - Ross & Jenny Penman

Conditional Registration Inspectors - Neville Stirton
0414 472 877
Geoff Smith
0458 777 339

Assn of British Car Clubs Reps - Christine Lyttle

National Assn Delegates - Gordon Lynas & Jim Phillips

AHOC Life Members - Don Read, Warwick Sell, Joe Armour, Christine Lyttle, Patrick Quinn, Terry Bancroft, Ray Roberts and David Mould.

If you want to send something by post, the Club's address is:-

AHOC (NSW) Inc
PO Box 6494
North Ryde NSW 2113

It would be appreciated if there were no phone calls to committee members after 9:00 PM.

EXHAUST LEAKS



By Patrick Quinn
(02) 4567 7380
0417 673 065
p_cquinn@tpg.com.au

Greetings and welcome to the December 2020 issue of the Flat Chat Newsletter.

Surely the most significant event for many of us during the last month has been the death of fellow club member Eric Rudd. So I thought the inclusion of the below well-known photo would be appropriate. Most would know that it shows two Austin-Healeys coming down the mountain at Bathurst. What it doesn't show is that the leading car, bravely driven by Peter Hopwood has just passed the trailing car driven by Denis Welch and what it also doesn't show is that the car Peter was driving was owned and prepared by Eric Rudd. Eric knew his Austin-Healeys, and while Peter was known for his skilful driving, Eric's patient and thoughtful skill at the preparation of that car should not be forgotten. Eric was a friend to all those who knew him and was passionate towards Austin-Healeys. He will be missed.

So what do we have in this month's Flat Chat? On the cover you will once again find words and photos courtesy of Julie Lee on attending a workshop day at the Central Coast home of Kerrie and Colin Rule. Embedded with Julie's words are some courtesy of Colin. Thank you to both of you.

Thank you to Gordon Lynas for his thoughtful words on his early associations with Eric Rudd, and thank you too to all those club members who kept still while I took a few photos when we gathered together in Eric's memory.

I know that everyone can't wait to read the minutes in each issue of Flat Chat and just to make your day there are two sets in this issue. One from the November meeting and the other from the Annual General Meeting. See I knew you would all be excited by this.

Congratulations to Natalina and Vincenzo Cessario on the marriage of their daughter Elizabeth to Karl Pillora. A very special day and hopefully made even more so by the inclusion of seven Austin-Healeys. You can read about it on page 15.

Thank you once again to the inimitable Ron Strange for his story of his rather eventful journey from his home just north of Sydney Harbour Bridge to the



workshop of the unrelated Greg at Chippendale. Talking to Greg, I have since found out that the carbon in the clutch thrust had worn completely away allowing metal to metal contact to such an extent that they jammed together physically stopping the engine.

Trust you enjoy this issue of the Flat Chat Newsletter and I look forward to receiving your photos and words on what you have been up to. Let's try and make the January issue chock-a-block full of interesting Healey and Austin-Healey reading.





Minutes of the General Meeting

Thursday, 5 November 2020.
Commenced: 7:40pm.
Venue - Via Zoom videoconference.

ATTENDEES

Refer Club point score list.

VISITORS & NEW MEMBERS

N/A

APOLOGIES

Patricia Bancroft, Glenn Barnes, Mal French, Patrick & Caroline Quinn, Pam & Doug Ross, Eric Rudd, Geoff Smith, Ron Strange

APPROVAL OF MINUTES

Resolved that the minutes of the General Meeting held 1 October 2020, as published in the November 2020 issue of Flat Chat, be accepted as a correct record of that meeting

PRESIDENT'S REPORT

Gordon advised that the North Ryde Golf Club was slowly loosening restrictions, but was still not available for AHOC general meetings. Depending on what happened over the next month or two, it was possible the AHOC would need to look for another venue for the January and February meetings.

Gordon also spoke of how deeply saddening it was for the AHOC to lose long-time member, Anne Read. Sincere condolences went out to Don and family.

VICE-PRESIDENT'S REPORT

No report.

SECRETARY'S REPORT

Julie advised that five completed Committee Member nominations had been received for the AGM by the cut-off date.

Relevant emails received since the October general meeting included:

- Online versions of the November issue of Healeys West (WA), October and November Healey Torque (Qld), October Rally Directions (CRC), October Speed Read (Motorsport Australia) and October Preserve (CMC)
- Offer of a Carbooks of New York 100 manual
- Spam, spam and more spam...

TREASURER'S REPORT

Funds as at 31 October 2020:

Debit card	\$230.34
Main Account	\$16,014.49
Cash Reserve	\$12,498.12
Charlie's Run	\$2,053.21
Term Deposit	\$78,006.98

John advised there hadn't been a great deal of activity for the month of October in relation to income or expenditure.

SOCIAL SECRETARY'S REPORT

Bruce gave an update on the events schedule. Planning for a Sydney workshop was well under way, with the first to be at Vince's workshop in the second week of February. Bruce was going to check out Colin Rule's Central Coast workshop on the coming weekend for ideas.

There are lots of activities planned for next year. As well as the Sydney workshops (proposed to be held at a couple of different venues), he also had garden/historic house visits lined up, with probably one every three months. The plan in March was to have a run to the artist Tim Storrier's house in Bowral. Another house, Highfields, just beyond the Blue Mountains, would probably be in October/November.

Bruce advised he hoped to have a calendar of events published in December. The events would of course be subject to any applicable COVID restrictions at the time.

WELFARE OFFICER'S REPORT

No Report

WEBMASTER'S REPORT

Jim advised that work was continuing on the website, including some simplification around admin roles. He was aware that some members had not received their welcome emails for the website, so they hadn't been able to set up their logins for the website. He was waiting on the website developer, Andrew, for a response on the issue.

Jim said he'd received an enquiry from someone wanting to put a link to their business on the Club website, but when Jim checked the link, it came up as an insecure website, plus the business appeared to



be of minimal use to members, so he decided to pass on it.

He would be uploading some more photos shortly, including of Vince and Natalie's daughter's wedding!

MEMBERSHIP

Christine advised of two new membership applications. She'd approved them as Associate Members in the interim, with the Committee to review the full memberships at the next meeting. She advised she would hand out new membership badges once members were able to meet in person again.

Onto the Christmas Party, North Ryde Golf Club had advised they could do Friday, 4 December as the Thursday was already booked. The Golf Club was open later on a Friday, so would probably be a better option anyway. Numbers were restricted to 60, and people had to be seated at all times. It would be a two-course menu and drinks. The Committee would be discussing options and cost at their next meeting so an email to members would come out after that with details.

EDITOR'S REPORT

On behalf of Patrick, Julie advised that Flat Chat had been sent out the previous day, with no bounce-backs. Patrick was always on the hunt for new material from members and he'd confirmed there would be a January issue of the newsletter.

Julie for Patrick Quinn

REGISTRAR

"Great to see the first 3000 to be sold in Australia back in our Club. Recently purchased by Tony Jansz as an anniversary gift for his wife Kathy, they are both looking forward to enjoying the car. We now have 195 cars conditionally registered through the AHOC.

I would ask that everyone have a close look at the changes to allowed modifications laid out in the November Flat Chat newsletter."

There was some discussion by members on the allowed modifications, particularly around whether an engineering inspection was required where seatbelts were installed, and also on indicator lights. It was agreed that the Committee would discuss these issues further at their upcoming meeting so Greg Strange was to email details of his concerns to Gordon and Julie.

Julie for Patrick Quinn

HISTORIAN

No report

LIBRARIAN

No report.

TECHNICAL OFFICER/CLUB EQUIPMENT/ SPARE PARTS

In response to Neville's question about windscreens for six-cylinder cars, Colin Rule advised that they would hopefully be available just before or after Christmas. A BJ7/8 would be \$260 and a six-cylinder roadster \$240. Colin added that he was hoping the windscreens for the 100s that he'd ordered would be ready for him to pick up tomorrow.

PUBLIC RELATIONS REPORT

Ross had nothing to report on public relations.

David Mould talked about having had his BN1 for 54 years and his BN7 for 42 years, and he'd been thinking about the whereabouts of some of the earlier members of the Club. Gordon thought it might be good to do a "where are they now" in *Flat Chat*.

CMC REPORT

Ray didn't have anything to report but advised that the Strathfield Golf Club, where the CMC met, was looking for business. Gordon said he'd look into this, plus the Committee could add it to their agenda for their next meeting.

ASSOCIATION OF BRITISH CAR CLUBS

Nothing to report

CSCA REPORT

CColin Goldsmith advised that the Jaguar Car Club upersprint held a couple of weeks ago had quite easily got to their limit of 90 cars. Apparently they'd had a good arrangement with SMSP to adjust the rental fee to match what they brought in.

The HSRCA had also held a meeting at Wakefield Park a few weeks back, which attracted a small Group 2 field of 12 to 14 cars. The last HSRCA meeting would be held at SMSP at the end of November and there'd be a GEAR day the first week in December. GEAR meetings are popular events, with over 80 participants at the last one.

There'd be one more for the year in December. Geoff said he'd heard strong talk of an Historic

race meeting at the end of November which Colin thought might be on, although Patrick noted there'd been a meeting scheduled for the last six months at Sydney Motorsport Park.

REGALIA

Back on the subject of windscreens, Colin advised that if he couldn't pick them up tomorrow, they wouldn't be available for his workshop on Saturday.

Terry Bancroft advised that he had model car on a plinth which he thought would have to be worth \$100-\$150. He was happy for this to be sold, with

Cont' from page 1

All had an interesting morning viewing 14 Austin-Healeys, an Aston Martin and an E-type V12. The library was in full swing, as well as regalia.

To accompany the usual cuppa and chat, there was an array of morning tea goodies to feast on, including another experiment from me – chocolate chunk and raspberry biscuits, which weren't too shabby! For once, Garry and I didn't have to rush off somewhere else, so we were able to spend a very pleasant time under the tree having a chat with everyone.

proceeds to go to the Club.

FOR SALE/WANTED

N/A

GENERAL BUSINESS

On behalf of the Club, Christine wished Shirley Mould a happy 80th birthday for November! She also confirmed she would reserve a couple of places for David and Shirley at the Club's Christmas Party.

Meeting concluded at 8:30pm.

Thanks once again to Colin and Kerrie for hosting this very popular event.

Colin reports that the next workshop is scheduled for Saturday 5th December and Bruce Ewan has the gearbox of his BJ7 booked in to be inspected. Also on the day will be a Christmas barbecue, which will be a fitting way to round off Saturday morning workshops held throughout the Covid year of 2020. "We did it!"



President's Message cont'

Club, being subject to a rather large fine we must stay within the rules, and that will almost certainly include some limitation on numbers attending each workshop. Hence, a booking system is almost certain to be necessary. By February we should also have a venue where we can resume our normal monthly General Meetings, so watch Flat Chat for announcements.

Sadly, in recent times we have lost three Aus-

tin-Healey stalwarts: Barry Birch, Anne Read, and most recently Eric Rudd. Our club is the poorer for their loss and we extend our and condolences to their families and friends. We share their sorrow.

As always, stay safe, be Covid sensible, and

Happy Christmas Healeying,

Gordon



Austin-Healey Owner's Club (NSW) Inc. Annual General Meeting

Minutes of the meeting held 5 November 2020 by Zoom videoconference

Present – refer Club Point Score List for attendees

Gordon Lynas, President and Chair of the meeting, called the meeting to order at 8:30 pm, and welcomed all attendees.

The Chair advised that no proxies had been received for the meeting.

1. Minutes of the 2019 Annual General Meeting

Draft minutes of the 2019 AGM had been published in the December 2019 edition of Flat Chat, plus they had been included in the AGM Notice which had been sent to members on 17 October 2020.

RESOLVED that draft minutes of the Annual General Meeting held 7 November 2019 be approved.

2. Committee Report

The Committee's report had been included in the AGM Notice.

RESOLVED that the Committee's Report for 2019/20 be noted.

3. Financial Statements & Reports

The Club's financial statements had been included in the AGM Notice, plus additional commentary emailed to members on 24 October 2020.

RESOLVED that the financial statements for the year ending 30 June 2020 be approved.

4. Election of Committee Members

The President handed the Chair to Jim Phillips to conduct the election of officeholders.

Jim thanked the outgoing Committee members, declared all positions vacant, then conducted the election of Committee members.

Completed nominations had been received prior to the meeting for the following roles, so each was duly elected by Members at the meeting:

- President – Gordon Lynas
- Vice President – Geoff Smith
- Secretary – Julie Lee
- Membership Secretary – Christine Lyttle
- Technical Officer – Neville Stirton

Nominations were taken from the floor for the following roles, and each was duly elected by Members at the meeting:

- Treasurer – John Sherman
- Public Officer – Alan Mitchell
- Club Registrar – Patrick Quinn
- Public Relations Officer – Ross Penman
- Regalia Officer – Colin Rule
- Webmaster – Jim Phillips
- Editor – Patrick Quinn
- Historian – Joe Armour
- Social Secretary – Bruce Ewan

Jim handed the Chair back to the re-elected President, Gordon Lynas.

There being no further business, the Chair closed the meeting at 8:50pm.

It's the time of the year for Christmas Spirit. It sure has come around fast this year even though it has been a year of uncertainty which has affected so many people. With restrictions being lifted and state borders opening we hope that everyone can celebrate the Christmas Spirit with their families and friends.

The Club will hold its annual Christmas Party at the Strathfield Golf Club on Thursday 17 December 2020. We have arranged a two-course meal with drinks and hope that members are available and can share the night out with fellow members. It has been so long since we have been able to have some social time together and hope that you will use this opportunity to gather together. Covid regulations will apply and all members will need to remain seated during the evening. Please send your payment of \$40 per person direct to the Club's bank account (see page 9) and look forward to seeing you there. If you require a special meal please advise. The details were sent to members via email though if you need further details please let me know and I will send to you. By the way the bookings close on 10 December 2020.

I was saddened to hear that Eric Rudd, another of our very active and long term members had passed away after a six month stay in hospital. My sincere condolences go to Jenny, who had been married to Eric for 48 years, their boys Tom and Phillip and their families both here and in New Zealand. Eric had served many years on the committee and we will miss him at our future events. RIP Eric.

We welcome the new members approved at the last committee meeting, Tony and Kath Jansz from Warrawee with a 1960 3000 MKI (ex-Lawrie Sorahan), Denis Kasza from Maroubra as an associate member with a 1961 Austin A99 Westminster and Michael Kelly from Darling Point with a 1966 3000 BJ8 (ex-Richard Horwood). We hope that you can all attend a social event or meeting soon.

I have also received a membership application from

Membership Report Christine Lyttle

0410 201 373

membership@austinhealeynsw.com.au



Giles Alexander who purchased a 1958 100/6 BN4 from The Healey Factory some years ago and has restored the car. Giles' membership will be tabled at the next Committee meeting pending finalisation of his documents and payment.

Geoff and Carol Golding are moving back to Australia from New Zealand and will be living in Bundanoon. They are shipping their 100 BN1 and look forward to seeing them at an event in 2021.

The December meeting has been cancelled as we are having the Christmas Party this month. We will commence having our General Meetings at the Strathfield Golf Club from Thursday 4 February 2021, so hopefully you will all be able to mark the date in your calendar and we will see you there. It will be great to meet up again for meetings.

Please don't forget to let me know advise me if you change your address, email or any other details online to ensure that we can keep your details as correct as possible.

Keep safe and well during the Christmas season.

I wish everyone a very happy Christmas and New Year and hope that we can hold more social events during 2021 within a safer environment.

Happy Healeying during isolation!
Christine Lyttle



A large, textured red Christmas ornament with a silver cap and a red ribbon bow at the top, positioned in the upper left corner of the invitation.

**Merry
CHRISTMAS**

You are invited to attend the

**Austin Healey Owners Club (NSW)
Christmas Party**

to be held at

**Strathfield Golf Club
52 Weeroona Road, Strathfield
On Thursday 17 December 2020
Commencing at 6.00pm**

A whimsical illustration of Santa Claus, dressed in his traditional red suit and hat, driving a red Austin Healey sports car. The car is overflowing with various Christmas gifts and decorations.

**2 Course Dinner
(Main and Dessert)
Drinks
Ticket price \$40 each
RSVP: 10 December 2020**

AHOC Bank Account - BSB 032 669 Ac 252564



Santa rushing to get to the Christmas Party.



Historic Vehicle Registration News

If you have a car on Historic Vehicle Registration you should read this.

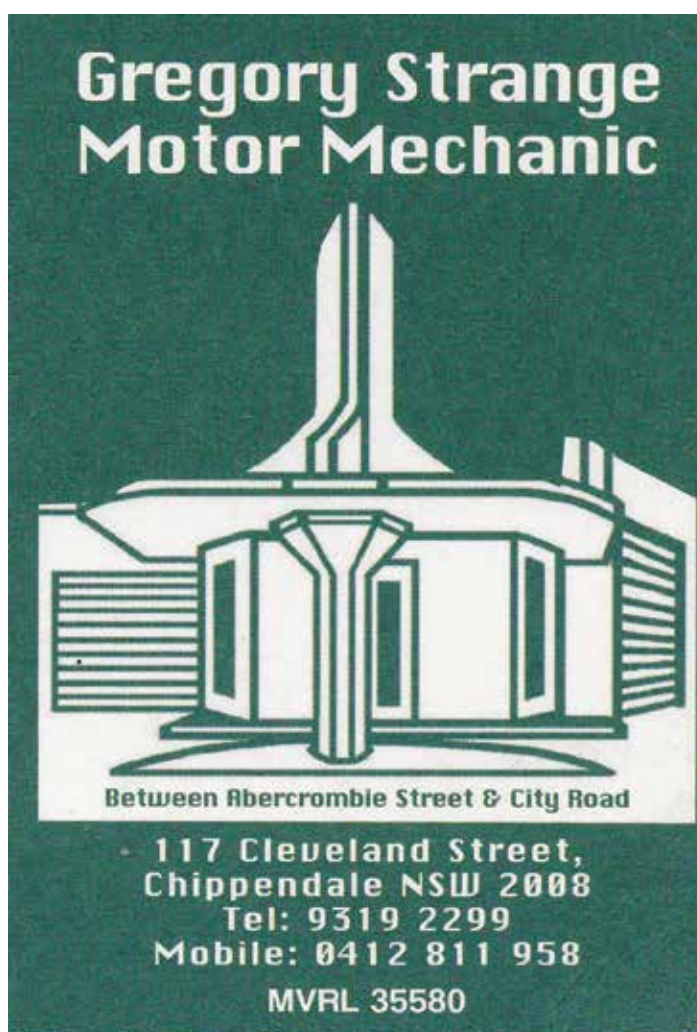
Last month we passed on the news of some changes that allowed those cars that had been modified away from showroom standard to be registered as Historic Vehicles. Most of these were good, such as engine, brake, suspension modifications and so on. All these would be highly useful to those members of our club and others who wanted to make such changes to their cars, but it did give rise to a couple of unforeseen questions.

In essence these questions centred on the areas of

the use of red tail lights as combined indicators and brakes lights and the inspection of the fitting of seat belts to those cars not so fitted when new.

On behalf of the AHOC, President Gordon has written to Transport for NSW seeking guidance and you will read the result here first.

We now have 196 cars on Historic Vehicle Registration and would you believe that over the last month I have not received a single question on how to renew your registration, but I'm still going to remind everyone of what happens when the time rolls around and you have received the RMS documentation in the post. That will include a single sheet with "Historic Vehicle Declaration" at the top in big friendly letters. Fill in the left side and post it to me, (see page two of this and previous Flat Chat Newsletters for my address) along with an indication that your car is roadworthy which can be a positive inspection result by our inspection officers (see page two for their contact details) or a pink slip from an Authorised Inspection Station. I will complete the right hand side and post back to you inside the stamped addressed envelope that you have also sent me. Once you get it back you can either go to your local Services NSW office to do the deed or post it to the RMS in Parkes along with a cheque or include your contact number so they can call you for your credit/debit card details.

The advertisement has a dark green background. At the top, the text "Gregory Strange Motor Mechanic" is written in a large, white, serif font. Below this is a white line-art illustration of a building with a prominent central tower and several windows. Underneath the illustration, the text "Between Abercrombie Street & City Road" is written in a smaller white font. At the bottom, the address "117 Cleveland Street, Chippendale NSW 2008" is listed, followed by the phone numbers "Tel: 9319 2299" and "Mobile: 0412 811 958", and the vehicle registration "MVRL 35580".

Thanks to AH Spares

Vale Eric George Rudd

by Patrick Quinn

Apart from the obvious, this year has been terrible, an “Annus Horribilis” with three prominent AHOC members no longer with us.

Barry Birch, Anne Read and you would have noticed elsewhere in this issue of the Flat Chat Newsletter news of the passing of Eric Rudd on 20 November at 78 years of age after a long illness.

I don’t recall when I first met Eric, but it would have been close to 30 years back. He had not long before joined the AHOC with a BJ8 and the news went out quickly that that there was a new member with a British car repair business in the suburb of Brookvale. It wasn’t long before club members were heading to Butler and Rudd for whatever they needed to be done to their Austin-Healeys. The Quinn Austin-Healey had its carburettors rebuilt there and Eric arranged for the late Bill Bressington to come in for his expert advice.

Of course it wasn’t just Austin-Healeys, as at the time we had a Jaguar XJ6 that needed a bit more than TLC but Eric in his cool, calm and knowledgeable way was there to assist. That was one of the Eric’s attributes that came across first and foremost. He was there to assist in a way that you knew would work out.

It wasn’t long before the proprietor-customer relationship gave way to friendship and I knew that it wasn’t restricted just to Caroline and me, as I am

sure that Eric’s friendly nature was there for everyone.

Eric’s expertise and level of knowledge was available to everyone and his holding of the position of Technical Officer on the AHOC Committee for many years was an example.

I can recall his excitement at the prospect of an All Healey race at Bathurst in 1988 and he started preparing a 100/6 for the event. Of course Eric knew that he wasn’t going to be the driver and for that he met the late Peter Hopwood which was certainly a worthwhile partnership. While Peter had a big heart, it was Eric’s expertise and his willingness for them to work together that provided the results.

After Butler and Rudd closed its doors, Eric was still out there helping his fellow club members. Numerous times he made the trek from the Northern Beaches to Kurrajong Heights to help with the Quinn Austin-Healey. He was here when the engine was gingerly extracted in July 2011 and again when it was slowly reinstalled in October 2013, plus was there for all the stages of rebuilding in between including that of the gearbox. He was here when it was ready to be fired up.

In between there was numerous phone calls about not only Austin-Healeys, but the world in general. It was good to have a chat at club meetings when he would arrive with mate John Sherman. Eric liked a



Vale Eric Rudd cont'

good chat with friends and appreciated those who took the trouble to call when his health started to fail him. I had the pleasure of speaking to him just a few days before John called with the sad news. Eric had said that he was looking forward to being home for Christmas. Sadly it wasn't to be.

Both Caroline and I will miss Eric and I am sure I speak for everyone that he will be greatly missed and send our condolences to Jenny, Tom, Phillip and families.

Eric and Henrietta

by Gordon Lynas

It was with great sadness that I learnt last Friday that Eric Rudd had passed away. Nearly 30 years ago Eric was recommended to me as someone who knew Austin-Healeys. I had finally achieved sufficient financial security to be able to indulge Henrietta, my '100', and I was slowly working my way through her 'bits', checking, restoring, or replacing as necessary.

One big 'bit'; that I wasn't game to pull apart myself was the gearbox and overdrive. So, I took it to Butler & Rudd. Eric stripped it, replaced a bearing or two, and put it back together. "It's OK" he said, "But it is well worn. If I were you, I'd look for a replacement box. This one might not last very long." Since then Henrietta has covered around 100,000 miles and that same box is still in the car. Last year the Healey Factory checked it over and gave me similar advice as Eric. "It's worn, but there is nothing actually wrong with it. Just use it carefully." I take that as a tribute to Eric's skill in rebuilding the gearbox so well.

Skip forward to 1995 and I was wanting to get the car roadworthy. This time the complete Henrietta was trailed to Butler & Rudd, by now in their new improved workshop at Brookvale. "You have to come and see this Gordon". That was Eric on the phone. "Just tell me." I replied. However he was insistent that I had to come and see 'it', for myself, whatever 'it' was. So later that afternoon Eric and I were looking at the rear bulkhead and he said "Just push your finger on that!" pointing to the lap seam between the inner wheel arch and the bulkhead. I pushed and my finger just went straight through! English winter road salt had got into the lap joint and rotted it away. The paint didn't look too bad, there just wasn't any metal underneath. Other seams were in a similar state. "Drive that car over a speed bump and it will just fall apart!" He mused.



So, Henrietta's skeleton was despatched to The Healey Factory for attention. After its return Eric and his team rebuilt the car with the ropery set of fibreglass panels that I had installed back in the '70s in England. (I was poor then.) Despite the panel quality, I thought he did a great job of reassembling the car, but as he always said, "It's a 30 foot car". Meaning in the correct light (dim) she looked quite good from 30 feet away. However he'd made sure that she was safe and went well! Butler & Rudd continued to look after Henrietta until the business was wound up. By then Eric had become a Austin-Healey Club friend and Louise and I had become fellow Charlie's Runners, so his connection with Henrietta continued.

I will always remember Eric as a fount of knowledge on all things Austin-Healey, as well as most other BMC products. He was a gentle, friendly and helpful man, his many friends will miss him.



A Drink with Eric

Over 70 family and friends gather together in the afternoon of Wednesday 2 December at Newport Bowling Club to share their memories of Eric Rudd. This included close to 40 members of the AHOC plus from Melbourne Rob Rowland of The Healey Factory as well as Peter Jackson and son Piers.

As the afternoon progressed it was John Sherman who welcomed everybody by speaking briefly on

his friendship with Eric. That was followed by Peter Jackson, friends of Eric from his sailing days and finalised by Jenny Rudd and son Tom.

While of course it was a sad occasion that brought people together, the afternoon was not a sad event as it was in keeping with Eric's ability of always seeing the positive side of life. It was an enjoyable afternoon, which Eric would have enjoyed.



Geoff Smith, George Goodare, Liz Goodare, Caroline Quinn, Christine Lyttle and Jenny Penman



Mal French, Rob Harrison and Toni Harrison



Colin Rule, John Wakeling and Kaye McIntyre



Piers Jackson, Peter Jackson, Chris Dimmock and Rob Rowland



Allan Whitehouse, Louise Lynas, Gordon Lynas, Dianne Lawlor and Greg Strange.



John Sherman remembering Eric Rudd.

The Healey Museum, Vreeland, Netherlands

I'm sure that most, if not all of you, will be aware of the excellent 'Healey Museum' in the Netherlands. This is particularly true if you attended the October General meeting when our guest of honour was Albert Hartink (the Healey Museum Foundation's Treasurer) who, courtesy of Zoom, showed us some of the beautiful and historic vehicles in the Museum.



Quoting from the Museum's website: "The main goal of the Healey Museum Foundation is to preserve the cultural heritage of Donald Mitchell Healey and the products of the Donald Healey Motor Company for future generations by conservation and exhibiting the rich history of the Healey brand and the people behind it." It is a terrific museum and you can get a little of its flavour and objectives at www.healeymuseum.nl

Now why am I writing about the Museum in this edition of Flat Chat? More than a few months ago Terry Wade of the Victorian AHOC started a move

through the National Delegates Meetings to make a joint donation to the Museum from the combined Australian Austin-Healey Clubs. Of course, such a proposal had to be discussed by each club before those who agreed could think about how such a joint donation might be achieved. Eventually Victoria, Queensland, NSW, and several generous individuals decided to contribute to the donation, which was co-ordinated by Neil Treggia of the Queensland AHOC. Suffice to say, we finally (and jointly) donated a total of \$7,750 to the Museum in November. The total donated is specifically related to a request from the Museum for assistance in preserving a number of special Healeys and Austin-Healeys that can be seen at the Museum.

I'm not sure that I will ever get to visit the Museum; however I do believe that there is a major benefit to ALL Healey and Austin-Healey owners in ensuring that there is a safe repository for original Donald Healey Motor Co. and Austin-Healey historical artefacts and documents. This donation will assist that project. If you should make the pilgrimage to Vreeland, be sure to seek out the plaque recording your donation!

Gordon Lynas



An Austin-Healey Wedding

By Vincenzo and Natalina Cessario

How thrilled and proud we were when on 30th October our daughter Elizabeth wed Karl Pillora. Thankfully the gods were on our side as the sun and weather were just perfect.

Both Elizabeth and Karl wanted Austin-Healeys involved in the ceremony and with thanks to fellow club members I had arranged for seven Austin-Healeys to drive the bridal party to St Charles Borromeo Catholic Church in Ryde.

Three black Austin-Healeys escorted the bride and bridesmaids to the church and four Austin-Healeys proceeded to Parramatta and picked up the groom

and groomsmen and escorted them to the church. The Austin-Healeys were black BJ8 (Terry Bancroft), black BJ8 (Ian Clayton), black BJ8 (our own), dark blue BJ7 (John Sherman), white over blue BN2 (George Goodare), blue over white BN2 (Richard Lloyd) and blue over white 100/6 (Jim Phillips).

Before leaving our house we dressed the cars with bridal ribbons and then organised them to be parked outside of our home at 45° for photos. After the ceremony Karl with Elizabeth drove our BJ8 to Banjo Patterson Park at Gladesville for photos.



Vale Gerry Coker 1922-2020



Gerald Charles Coker, known to all as “Gerry,” was born on June 24th, 1922. He is known in the automotive world for his styling and body design of the Healey 100.

Gerry’s design talent became apparent early with childhood doodles of motorcars. He began training as an engineer in 1939 when he was apprenticed with the Rootes Group where he worked with experimental designs for armoured vehicles and other military vehicle components prior to and during WW2.

He joined the Donald Healey Motor Company as body engineer in 1950, his first job was to input to the design of the Nash-Healey and Three Litre Convertible bodies as they were delivered from coach-builder Panelcraft.

Early in his period at the DHMC, Healey challenged Gerry to show him a sports car design, and in late 1950, he created the design of what would become the Austin-Healey 100. This timelessly beautiful sports car stole the show in October 1952 when it debuted as the Healey 100 at the Earls Court Motor Show.

Gerry also styled the Austin-Healey Streamliner (the “pretty one,” he says) that was driven to 192.7 mph at the Bonneville Salt Flats in 1954. Just prior to moving on from the DHMC, Gerry developed the preliminary body design for the forthcoming Austin-Healey Sprite, which made its successful appearance in 1958. Budget considerations caused the Sprite’s final design to be altered considerably. This early design did not include the unique headlamps which caused the first Sprites to be called either “Frogeye” or “Bugeye” depending on which continent you were on.

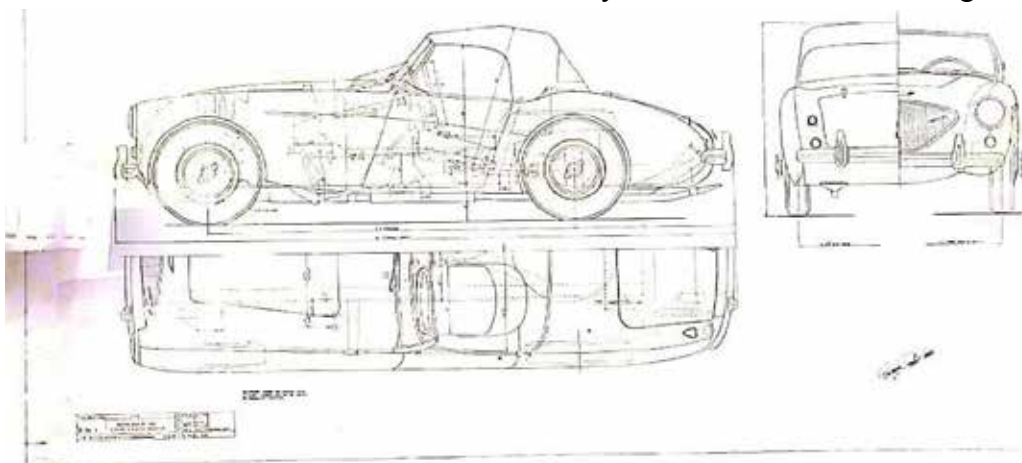
Gerry and Marion, were married in June 1953 near Coventry, Warwickshire. Their engagement coincided with Gerry’s design work for the Healey Hundred. Their wedding almost didn’t take place, as that June weekend coincided with the 24 Hours of Le Mans. Donald Healey had entered four cars (two Austin-Healeys and two Nash-Healeys) and wanted Gerry to attend the race. He did not. Marion recalls that “I won that one!”

In 1957, the Cokers left England for life in America. Gerry worked at the Chrysler Corporation for about five years before moving on to the Ford Motor Company, where he worked until 1987, when he retired as a Senior Product Design Engineer. It was Gerry who designed the famous dual action station wagon tailgate; he and Ford hold a patent on his ingenious design. (seen in Australia on the Ford Falcon)

Gerry and Marion Coker became familiar faces to many Austin-Healey owners who met them at various Austin-Healey events over the years.

Gerry Coker passed away surrounded by family on November 13th, 2020.

Every time you look at your Austin-Healey, thank Gerry Coker for its timeless design.



Member Profile - Get to know your fellow Members



Gordon & Louise Lynas

What model Austin-Healey do you own?

100, BN1.5 (i.e. it has had BN2 brakes and axle, but BN1 gearbox from new.)

When were you first attracted to Austin-Healeys?

In 1960 when my brother arrived home in what is now my car.

How long have you owned your Austin-Healey?

53 years

You owned an Austin-Healey in the UK?

Yes, the same one, christened Henrietta by a girl-friend at Uni'.

How long to ship it to Australia?

Louise made me bring the car to Australia, for which I will be forever grateful. It travelled in the bottom of the container of our furniture and household stuff. I think it took about two or three months from packing in England to delivery to us in Gosford.

What other cars do you own or have you owned?

Lots, the interesting ones include: a Bond Bug 700ES (unbeatable off the lights to 35 mph and easy as a motor bike to park anywhere in the City); an MGB GT; a Fiat 124 Sport Coupé; an Alfa Romeo Spyder (great fun, but the electrics made Lucas seem like quality products); a Discovery 4 (the best all-round performer I've ever owned as it would go anywhere easily and in comfort), and I'm currently looking after my son's Alfa GT – much faster than the Spyder, but even less reliable electrics. Louise's first car was a Fiat 500, and she quite liked driving the Fiat 124. These days she has given up on manual cars, and I can't get her to update her Mitsubishi Verada!

What is your favourite thing about your Austin-Healey?

We both love open air cruising in country NSW.



In the North Yorkshire Moors c 1962



Henrietta, Gordon & Louise at 'Classic Yass'

What is the most memorable moment in your Austin-Healey?

Fitting me and four girls into the car.

What is the worst moment in your Austin-Healey?

See above.

How often do you take your Austin-Healey for a drive?

As often as we can, usually a couple of times a month for a decent drive and occasional trips to Buntings. No roof means it will take things that are just way beyond a tin top, however big.

Is there an Austin-Healey that you have seen and long to own?

I'd like a 4000 but there aren't too many around.

Do you enjoy the car club events?

Absolutely!

Do you enjoy the monthly general meetings?

Usually

Have you served time on the Committee?

Five years as Secretary, now in second year as President.

Continued

What is your typical type of event you like to attend in your Austin-Healey?

Having a few days away with our cars and other club members

What is your favourite Austin-Healey event?

Charlie's Run

Do you attend the annual National Rally?

When I can, but dates sometimes clash with Sail Port Stephens, or commitments at the NSW Railway Museum!

What do you like about the Austin-Healey Rallies?

Meeting lovely people from other clubs.

You organise the Charlie's Runs, do you enjoy running these?

Of course – I wouldn't do it if I didn't enjoy the research as much as the results.

Are you technical savvy with your Austin-Healey, if so would you like to hold a technical event or would you like to attend one?

I'm very much an amateur mechanic. Poverty previously has acquainted me with all parts of my car except the differential, but I wouldn't profess any great knowledge. Nowadays I pay others, so I wouldn't want to host a technical event.

What type of technical area would you like to know about your Austin-Healey?

Installing a brake booster or power steering.

Have you owned other makes of sports cars? What were they and how do they compare to an Austin-Healey?

My Bond Bug was great fun in the city. Very cute, easily parkable, terrific power/weight ratio, but not enough HP to be dangerous. Some other owners managed to make their Bugs fall-over in corners, but I never managed that trick. The MGB GT was an improvement on my 100 as it kept me dry, was comfortable and had similar performance. The Alfas are great drivers' cars, but the electrics make them randomly unreliable. I did think long and hard to see if I could make the 100's hood as simple, dry and easy to erect as the Spyder's. (I failed.)

Who in the Austin-Healey fraternity would you like to have a dinner party with?

Someone who can talk about more than just Austin-Healeys.

What Austin-Healey person would you like to get to know better?

Couldn't possibly say.



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Not the NRMA

by Ron Strange

On my way to get the gearboxclutchthingamejig fixed at Mechanical Strange's garagarama one fine morning, I found myself on the dark side of the bridge when the box decided it wasn't gearing any more today.

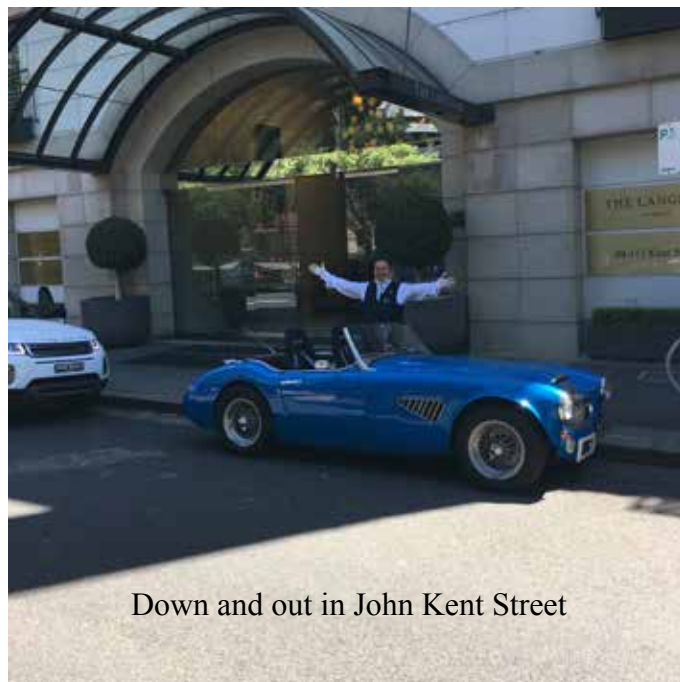
I will be ever grateful to Paul Hogan who as you know built the bridge and had the foresight to realise that stricken cars needed to coast downhill off that end of the bridge to John Kent Street.

Stranded there, I made the obvious phone call and before too long they arrived in their Dodge Ram, six people emerged from this truck, firstly The Cop clutching the most enormous 15 inch wrenches, one in each hand and muttering something about "YOU CAN HANG OUT WITH ALL THE BOYS. The Biker then emerged expertly riding on two trolley jacks like skateboards with a fist full of screwdrivers. The Cowboy meandered along, stroked his chin a lot and looking for someone to shoot.

Lurking menacingly across the road, the Sydney City Parking Ranger kept a very close eye on the situation and was obviously intimidated by my new buddies and didn't interfere. The Indian Chief (First American) defied the traffic and galloped (without his horse) across to explain to the Ranger; the car had electric petrol vulcanisation issues and we'd be mo-seying along as soon as Hiawatha arrived down from Terry's Hill with the anti-vulcanising tomahawk. The Ranger nodded knowingly and said, no problem, it happens all the time with Austin-Healeys.

The Indian Chief (First American) then gathered up some McDonalds and Hungry Jack debris that frequents this part of town, built a fire and sent a smoke signal message to Mechanical Strange to advise of our future arrival, but unbeknown to us, his garage being so close to the university, the signals were intercepted and directed straight to Beijing for some reason.

When The GI arrived along with The Construction Worker who just gazed lovingly at the cranes nearby, I realised they were the VILLAGE PEOPLE.



Down and out in John Kent Street

It was about now I began to be suspicious and I checked my phone to see if Mechanical Strange had acknowledged the smoke signals when I realised I had mistakenly called the YMCA and not the NRMA.

Desperately, on the phone again I accidentally called the RSPCA who naturally knew lots about injured and stranded elephants and giraffes, but unfortunately they didn't know anything about broken down Austin-Healeys and suggested I call the NRMA.

Back to square one.

Hello, NRMA yes? I have this Austin Healey that needs to be picked up and taken to Cleveland Street.....

'Yes! Yes!, I know mate, they all end up there in Chippendale eventually, I'll send a tow truck.

Footnote; In the words of the great Molly Meldrum, "Do yourself a favour" and reverse yourself 42 years, download the Village People video. If you don't smile or laugh there's something wrong with you. Or me?

New Members' Cars

The 3000 Mk1 of Alan and Jo Davidson



The BN4 of Giles Alexander



Austin A99 of associate member Denis Kasza



D.S. Engineering

by Rob Harrison

If you were involved in Austin-Healeys during the late 1960s and early 1970s you will recall that spare parts, accessories and go faster bits were in very short supply. The likes of the providers that exist today were many years into the future. I recall in Sydney some spares were available direct the small number of BMC outlets and dealers that existed at the time, plus a few bits were available from outlets such as Warnerfords and Lynx. Outlets that dealt specifically with Austin-Healeys just didn't exist.

There was however an option and the below message from club member Robert Harrison brought back memories.

How things have changed. Back in the very early '70s there were very few companies in the UK specialising in Austin-Healeys, i.e outside the Donald Healey Motor Company. However, the most prolific was DS Engineering and on a trip to the UK in 1972 my aim was to call in on them while in London, as they advertised in Motor Sport magazine and produced some nice modifications for big Healeys. As was often the case back then, you would expect an



exciting workshop full of inspiration, but what a surprise it was for us when we turned up. As you know companies such as Denis Welch, Cape, JME, Rawles etc and here in Australia The Healey Factory are all very impressive. The Austin-Healey owner is very spoilt these days

Extra Curriculum Activities



Member Patrick Townshend (100) seen exercising his Valiant Charger in a Regularity event at the HSRCA's Spring Festival meeting at Wakefield Park. Seth Reinhardt Photo.

Recently after buying two Mk1 Austin-Healey Sprites from the US, 100 owner Andrew Markrink could resist this Renault Floride on sale in WA. Released in 1958 the Floride was built on the Renault Dauphine floorpan and powered by 845cc to 1,108cc four cylinder engines. However this one is different as it's been converted to electric with battery power.



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FOR SALE

Healey Tickford with 2 ½ litre Riley engine and gearbox as a rolling chassis. This is the remains of a Tickford which was burnt out in a hanger fire some 35 years ago. Mileage approximately 55,000 from new. Scuttle and dashboard have been removed since photo was taken. The rear of the chassis is showing rust but it would be a good basis for constructing an E series Silverstone replica. Drawings are available. Project is located in Perth. \$17500 ono. (08) 9295 4592



Flat Chat Back Issues

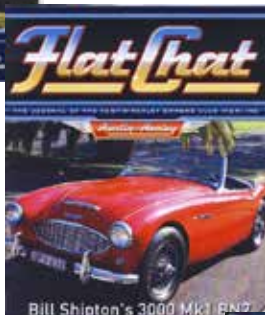
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Interesting Things for Sale

Stranger in a Strange Land

How about a 1955 100 BN1 that's been in single ownership for 65 years? It's in the wonderfully named California town of Copperopolis and as you see from the photos it's right hand drive. It's for sale by auction on www.hemmings.com/auctions/search? and at the time of writing, the bidding has risen to US\$36,500 with six days to go.

The chassis number is BN1 224837 and there is 113,971 miles on the clock, but what makes it interesting is that it was sold new in Australia in 1955

and its first owner took it to the US where it's been ever since. Apart from that, there really isn't anything special about it.

At the time of writing the bidding has risen to just over \$43,000 in our dollars. That's good value when you think about it, but if you were to bring it here there would be shipping, GST on everything and import agent fees etc etc.

Thanks to Terry Bancroft for letting us know about this car.



Badge looks Good

Probably the best description of this car was that the front badge looked good, but the rest was horrible.

This one owner BJ7 was for sale in the UK and has certainly seen better days. It was auctioned on eBay UK saying that the car requires a very brave and total restoration.

If you thought Colin Rule's BN2 was in a bad way before he started, I think this sad car is far worse. Much of the chassis is but a memory and even the engine rocker cover is rusted through.

The photo of the car together dates from 1963.

Did it sell? Yes it did for £7,811 or the equivalent of Au\$14,191.47.



Barn Find Nash-Healey

It's great to see that the Nash-Healey is creating interest in the US. With just over 400 built they are not exactly thick on the ground anywhere in the world and as far as it's known there are just three in Australia.

Initially the Nash-Healey was fitted with open bodywork by Panelcraft Sheet Metal and later with open and coupe bodywork by Pinin Farina (later titled Pininfarina). The Nash-Healey was also the most successful of all the Donald Healey Motor Company

cars at the Le Mans 24 hour race.

This 1954 Nash-Healey Le Mans coupe was recently auctioned on the US site Bring-a-Trailer and is one of 90 built for the final year of production. It was reportedly last driven under its own power in the 1980s. It was then stored in a barn for approximately 20 years and offered by the seller on behalf of his late owner's estate as a non-running project with spare parts.

It sold for US\$23,000 or Au\$31,031.



Photos of Interest



London Motor
Show in 1955



Pleased that it doesn't
get quite so cold here.



Tyres should be changed at least every seven to eight years.



Couldn't resist.

With permission of Derwin Hope

THE HOPE-HEALEY STORY

by Derwin Hope

For as long as I can remember, cars have always held a special place in my mind. Earliest memories are of Dinky Toy racing cars travelling down slopes and shooting off, the axles liberally dosed with 3 in 1 to make your car go faster and further than that of your competitors. My father's cars evolved through Morris, Sunbeam and Alvis until he alighted on Jensen – beginning with a wonderful silver 541 that he took me to school in, the first of many Jensens he was to have. Much later I acquired a Jensen SP of my own and restored it to concours condition in an era when they were almost universally scrapped and pulled apart for the more profitable activity of selling off spares. The story of my SP and its salvation was featured in the August 2018 edition of Classic Cars and the car continues to be featured in prestige classic car shows.

But over the years I have always loved the Healeys. My earliest abiding memory of them was when a new bright red 100/6 arrived in our village with a young (early 20's) Fleet Air Arm officer at the wheel who lived with his parents in the house next to the church. Oh my! What a head-turner in those austere days of the mid-50's! It was not long before my mate Robert and I, as boy scouts, tentatively made our way up the drive to knock on his door to ask if we could clean his car for Bob-a-Job week and then perhaps have a ride in it. He duly obliged and we were thrilled. Sadly, it was not long thereafter when he was killed in a flying accident after his plane went off the end of an aircraft carrier and plunged into the sea. The Inquiry into his death decreed that from now on all aircraft carriers should have an elevated ramp at the front of the deck to assist in take-off and landing, and whenever I now see this feature on any aircraft carrier my mind always goes back to him and his lovely Healey.

Perhaps the Healey experience in our village influenced my mother, for she – always also one with an eye for nice cars – later persuaded my father to buy her an Austin-Healey 3000 which, for many years, provided her and the family with great enjoyment. Later, in the early 1970's when Jensen and Healey combined to produce the Jensen-Healey, I became the proud owner of a buttercup yellow one that I drove

for many years around the UK and Europe with my then girlfriend Heidi (now my wife), which was followed by 3 Porsche 911's, before more mundane cars became the order of the day when children arrived. But I never lost my love of Jensen or Healeys as very special cars.

As my legal career took off and my family commitments grew, I kept my interest alive by reading and researching all I could about these two marques. I learnt how Donald Stokes cruelly parted Austin from Healey in 1968, just at the time when the Healeys were seeing the light on a new generation of Healeys that would have been, I believe, magnificent. Not only had there been the Rolls-Royce powered 4000, but of more interest for the longer term were the ideas that Healey and MG had put together for a new Sprite/Midget, with Geoff devising the mid-engined WAEC (Wheel At Each Corner) Sprite that he drove for about 18 months to test his ideas. The Healeys certainly felt by now that mid-engined sports and racing cars were the way forward for the future, as also shown by the last 3 cars the Healeys bravely raced under their own name at Le Mans from 1968 to 1970 – and which have so splendidly been portrayed recently by David Matthews in his 2 volume history: "From Gullwing to Spyder."

But with the need to do something quickly at Jensen after the loss of their Austin-Healey contract, the Jensen-Healey intervened in this progression. At the start all looked well. The new car was hailed by the motoring press as a concept that had Donald Healey's ingenuity, practicability and panache stamped all over it, for in an era when British dropheads had been sought after and respected throughout the world, he had produced some of the best. The Healeys had also chosen to now collaborate in the future with Lotus, and a contract was signed with Lotus to provide the engine for the car, the first time Lotus's own 2 litre engine had been used in any vehicle. And the bodywork was to be built by Jensen, as the Austin-Healey 3000 had been, so the signs looked good.

But all did not turn out well. The car proved to be no real successor to the 3000, being aimed by Jensen more at the larger MGB market, and the engine soon showed itself as being under-developed and unreliable, causing problems in

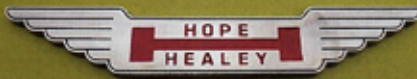


particular all over America (its biggest market), with Colin Chapman under the contract Jensen had signed with him being able to avoid compensation claims coming back to him. The oil crisis hit sales of Jensen Interceptors, and when the Healeys proposed a "shooting break" or GT version of their convertible, the Jensen management refused to allow the Healey name to be put on it, even wanting for a time to call it "the new Jensen Interceptor" instead. It is said that this attitude from the Jensen management was the final straw for Donald and Geoff, who walked away from Jensen at the end of 1973, deeply upset at the way they had been treated by them.

The car however soldiered on. In 1973 and again in 1974 racing versions won the Sports Car Club of America championships, and very narrowly missed out in 1975. An updated version won again in 1995, showing Donald and Geoff's basic concept was no bad car. Meanwhile Jensen had produced a Mark 2 version of the road car in 1974 – a much better car, but nevertheless one that still became unfairly but understandably bedevilled with bad headlines such as: "Give a dog a bad name..." etc. Production lasted until 1975, when Jensen became insolvent (10,000 Jensen-Healeys by then having been sold). Interceptors also stopped being produced, and the Jensen GT (with the name of Healey still on the engine rocker covers!) introduced by the administrators to try and save the company. It failed, and Jensen closed in May 1976, with some attempts to revive it thereafter which, to date, have also failed.

This latter history of the Healeys greatly saddened me. Donald and Geoff and their loyal teams had produced some wonderful cars over the years and now it seemed to me that both the Austin and then the Jensen managements had treated them very badly, to say nothing of the financial disaster all this must have caused them. In view of past history, it was even claimed that the Healeys could not now legally use their own name in respect of any future cars. I felt desperately sorry for them





and wanted somehow to do my bit to show that all was not lost and that the sun could shine again on the Healey world.

In 1988 I began mentally assessing how this could be done, not as a paper exercise but by producing an actual "new" Healey. I decided to start where the Healeys had left off 15 years earlier with the Jensen-Healey, and assessed critically every aspect of the car with a view to now making it a worthy successor to the 3000 rather than an MGB replacement. This, to me, obviously meant changing the engine and gearbox to something more appropriate. The racing experiences both in America and also in England (with Dealer Team Vauxhall and the famous "Droop Snoot" cars that had the same basis as the Jensen-Healey) showed that the car could handle greater power, and looking at the engine bay of the Jensen-Healey I could see no reason why a suitable V8 would not fit in there beautifully without the need for bodywork modification. The Lotus engine was a Slant-4 and the Healeys had designed the bay with matching slant sides. I thought I could do it without even having to use the offset bulge on the bonnet.

My engine of choice was the Rover V8, together with the LT77 5-speed gearbox that went with it. Not only did I love this engine, but it with this gearbox was also a contemporary of the car, which was important to me. I did not know until much later that Geoff had worked in Vehicle Development at Rover after he left Jensen, and he was to tell me that "everyone at Rover had a love for the V8." It came as no surprise when he told me that.

By the middle of 1990 I had produced my red prototype, and wanted in particular to know what the Healeys thought of it. Sadly Donald had died by then, but Geoff was living at Barford and I wanted him to see the car, especially as I knew he was the engineer in the family working with his father and I had the ultimate respect for his opinion. I wrote to him and a meeting was arranged; he told me he could not wait to see the car. This proved to be the case, for no sooner had I pulled up outside his home than he came out in his carpet slippers, gesturing for me to click open the bonnet – I hadn't even gone to his door to introduce myself! As soon as he lifted the bonnet he exclaimed: "Why didn't we think of this!" He looked it all over carefully and it is no exaggeration to say that he was thrilled at what he saw. He had never before linked this car with this engine, but had no hesitation in approving what he saw. I, of course, was delighted and so pleased to see him so enthusiastic about it. I took him for a run in it and then spent hours at his home discussing it, the Healey history and the type of cars he and his father would have liked to produce if they had been free to do so, based on what they had been doing in the late 1960's.

I wrote about my V8 prototype and my meeting with Geoff for the August 1990 edition of Rev Counter, calling the car at that time the

Jensen V8 Healey. Apart from 2 positive articles in motoring magazines, describing the car as "Born Again" and praising its new engineering, nothing further however happened at that time. I drove the car for some time, but then sold it to an enthusiast and lost track of it when I moved due to my work commitments. The Jensen Owners Club could only tell me later that it disappeared from DVLA records in about 2010.

The car might have disappeared, but it was not forgotten by me. Nor were the Healeys. Geoff had sadly died in 1994 but I treasured what he had said about my ideas, work and ability with the Healey and had given me signed written authority to produce such cars in the future. I knew now that I was the only person in the world to have such signed encouragement and authority and so I kept a close eye on how the Healey marque might progress in the future. I watched as Healey family members sold up and how Tim Fenna and Daniel Schlatter failed in their efforts. Between 2012 and 2018 nothing happened when it should have done, and by 2018 I found that the Healey companies had been scheduled as "dormant." To my mind this was not the Healey legacy that I wanted to see happen and so decided to try again to see if I could do something.

By now I had retired and had nearly completed one of my aims on retirement – to write Charles Dickens' real and true life story using his own words (see: www.dickensmylife.com), so my thoughts began turning to the Healey V8 again. Could I now produce another new Healey, using all the things I had learnt 30 years before, and now having Geoff's written authority to do so? I decided to give it another go, and to see now what Healey enthusiasts in particular around the world would think of my ideas having fully discussed them with Geoff and gained his approval. I also turned the clock back nearly 50 years and managed to track down (through the assistance of the "Droop Snoot Group") the only surviving member of the original DTV (Dealer Team Vauxhall) racing team – Gerry Johnstone, the chief engineer to Bill Blydenstein, when they were producing and racing the DTV cars that were driven so spectacularly by Gerry Marshall. It was really enjoyable and rewarding talking with him about those times and the way in which he made the cars handle so well.

My task now was to get a reasonable base car that I could work on. I found one in Bexhill-on-Sea, a buttercup yellow one that was virtually identical to the one I had bought new in 1974. I also found a really good mechanic to assist me who, with his mate, turned out to be brilliant. I set about sourcing all the parts needed and built up a voluminous file in the process, but found that even now it was possible to get them. I stuck to using all the components I could from the 1970's that were available when the Healeys first developed the car, but with the intent now on producing the true successor to the 3000. Once the mechanical side was done, I took the car to Bill Rawles for him and his team to do up the bodywork to the standard I required. They did an excellent job and I was delighted

when Bill wrote to me saying: "I must say, I was impressed with the quality of the installation of the V8. It makes the car look, sound and perform the way it should have in the 70's". This was exactly what I had set out to achieve and hoped others would find the same.

My last task was to find a name for the car. Because of the history and the type of car it had now become, I considered it should no longer have the name Jensen associated with it for the future. It is obviously a 3500 V8 but not an Austin-Healey, nor simply a Healey, and my mind went to what I had read in Peter Garnier's biography of Donald Healey when, on a transatlantic crossing in December 1949, Donald had had a chance meeting with George Mason, the President of the Nash Kelvinator Corporation and the Nash-Healey had resulted. My meeting with Geoff had been a planned rather than a chance one, I had produced a working prototype of a new Healey and Geoff had totally approved of it. Moreover, he had given me written authority to continue this into the future and had told me he was sure his father would have felt likewise.

I have accordingly decided to name my venture "Hope-Healey", have trade marked this name and, with Daniel Schlatter's approval, the logo also that represents this. I know what Geoff wanted to happen and I am going to try and provide it for him to honour his and his father's memory. The hours I spent with Geoff were wonderful, and I am determined to do all I can to now bring something back to the future of the Healey marque. I realise that some will only want a past for the Healeys and I respect that view, but I believe that Healeys can and do have a great future that is possible without in any way affecting the past – just so long as it is totally in keeping with the things I discussed at length with Geoff. I now have 10 years to see if I can prove I am worthy of that legacy. I hope you will give me the chance to do so.

